

The Distortions of al-Kulaynī

Bismillāh al-raḥmān al-raḥīm...

A few years have passed since I first compiled the distortions by Ibn Bābawayh al-Qummī, famously known as al- Ṣadūq, with the intention of strengthening the conclusion of al-Majlisī after coming across a distortion: “This report is taken from al-Kāfī and it has suffered from strange alterations which cause mistrust towards al-Ṣadūq. It seems he only did this in accordance with the school of the people of justice.”¹ So, I gathered forty of these reports, then published it in a short book called *The Distortions of al-Ṣadūq*.

For a long period, I had no strong position towards al-Kulaynī, and wasn’t sure as to whether the reports that are ascribed to the scholars of *ahlulbayt* were his own doing or others. So, I went ahead and thoroughly studied the first half of *Uṣūl al-Kāfī* to determine whether he too was guilty of distorting reports.

This short treatise is a continuation of the previous project which aims to display the evolution in the narrations attributed to *ahlulbayt*. This project would remain incomplete without examining the reports of he who was given the title of *Thiqat al-Islām*.

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¹ Al-Majlisī, *Biḥār al-Anwār*, 5/156.

The Biography of al-Kulaynī

He is Muḥammad bin Ya‘qūb bin Ishāq al-Kulaynī, from the village of Kulayn near al-Rayy. Al-Najāshī described him as, “The *shaykh* and head of our companions in his time in al-Rayy. He was the most reliable of people.”¹

Al-Ṭūsī said: “He was referred to as Abū Ja‘far al-A‘war (the one-eyed). He was of an elevated status and was knowledgeable in narrations.”²

His book, *al-Kāfī* is not only his most famous work, but it is the most authoritative Shī‘ī work, due to it being an early compilation with connected chains to the *ahlulbayt*. This book is split into three sections: the *Uṣūl* for creedal matters, the *Furū‘* for jurisprudence, and the *Rawḍa*. It was written during a span of twenty years and contains over sixteen thousands narrations.

It is said that al-Kulaynī had also written the following: *A Refutation to the Qarāmiṭa*, the *Treatises of the Imams*, a book on dream interpretations, a book on *rijāl*, and a book of poetry about the Imams.³

He was buried at the Kūfa gate in Baghdad and there is a difference of opinion on whether the year of death was 328 or 329 AH.⁴

¹ Al-Najāshī, *Rijāl al-Najāshī*, p. 377.

² Al-Ṭūsī, *Rijāl al-Shaykh*, p. 439.

³ Al-Najāshī, *Rijāl al-Najāshī*, p. 377.

⁴ Al-Ṭūsī, *Fihrist al-Ṭūsī*, p. 166; Al-Najāshī, *Rijāl al-Najāshī*, p. 378.

Objection: The Distortions are from Scribes

Those that object to the accusations of distortions often resort to accusing anonymous scribes, which is an objection that lacks weight. Those that wish to accuse scribes need to provide a manuscript that includes the wording that acquits al-Kulaynī, especially since classical scholars ascribed these wordings to al-Kulaynī as well. Otherwise, accusations against scribes are baseless.

Objection: The Distortions are from other Narrators in the Chain

I have previously demonstrated, in *The Distortions of al-Ṣadūq*, a probabilistic calculation that leads us to the conclusion that the probability that Ibn Bābawayh distorted at least one report in the first chapter, which consists of ten narrations, is 99.7%.¹ This is because Ibn Bābawayh is the common factor in these traditions. However, there won't be a need for such calculations with al-Kulaynī, who has undeniably manipulated a report he heard from his teacher Muḥammad bin Yaḥyā al-ʿAttār. This will be shown in the first example below.

One may then ask, “Even if we do concede that al-Kulaynī tampered with one report, why assume he tampered with the others?”

The response to this is that the methodology of the scholars of *ḥadīth* is to critique reports based on the weakest link. If one narrator has a bad memory and another is a liar, it is natural to accuse the liar when a distortion is found. While a trustworthy narrator is still prone to error, the scholars of *ḥadīth* would only weaken those of a lower reliability, unless there was good evidence to suggest otherwise.

¹ Al-Bahraini, *Taḥrīfāt al-Ṣadūq*, p. 22.

Distortion 1

Al-Kulaynī said: Muḥammad bin Yaḥyā has narrated from Muḥammad bin al-Ḥusayn from Ja‘far bin Bashīr from Fuḍayl from Ṭāhir from Abū ‘Abdillāh (a.s.). He said that Abū ‘Abdillāh (a.s.) would blame ‘Abdullāh, reprimand, and advise him, saying, “Why can’t you be like your brother? By Allah, I observe light in his face.” ‘Abdullāh said, “Why? Isn’t my father and his father one? Isn’t my mother and his mother one?” Abū ‘Abdillāh (a.s.) then said, “He is from me, and you are my son.”¹

قال الكليني: محمد بن يحيى، عن محمد بن الحسين، عن جعفر بن بشير، عن فضيل، عن طاهر: عن أبي عبد الله عليه السلام، قال: كان أبو عبد الله عليه السلام يلوم عبد الله ويعاتبه ويعظه، ويقول: ما منعك أن تكون مثل أخيك، فوالله، إني لأعرف النور في وجهه؟ فقال عبد الله: لم؟ أليس أبي وأبوه واحدًا، وأمي وأمه واحدة؟ فقال له أبو عبد الله عليه السلام: إنه من نفسي وأنت ابني.

This narration is also narrated by ‘Alī ibn Bābawayh, the father of al-Ṣadūq.

He said: Muḥammad bin Yaḥyā has narrated from Muḥammad bin al-Ḥusayn from Ja‘far bin Bashīr from Fuḍayl from Ṭāhir from Abū ‘Abdillāh (a.s.). He said that Abū ‘Abdillāh (a.s.) would blame ‘Abdullāh, reprimand, and advise him, saying, “Why can’t you be like your brother? By Allah, I observe light in his face!” ‘Abdullāh said, “Isn’t my father and his father one and my mother and his mother one?” Abū ‘Abdillāh (a.s.) then said, “Ismā‘īl is from me, and you are my son.”²

علي ابن بابويه: محمد بن يحيى، عن محمد بن الحسين، عن جعفر بن بشير، عن فضيل، عن طاهر، عن أبي عبد الله عليه السلام، قال: كان يلوم عبد الله ويعاتبه ويعظه ويقول: ما يمنعك أن تكون مثل أخيك؟ فوالله إني لأعرف النور من وجهه! فقال عبد الله: ليس أبي أبوه واحدًا؟ وأمي وأمه واحدة؟ فقال أبو عبد الله عليه السلام: إن إسماعيل من نفسي وأنت ابني.

Notice how both al-Kulaynī and ‘Alī ibn Bābawayh are quoting Muḥammad bin Yaḥyā³ and yet include a significant change.

The distortion is clear since the original report points to the *imāmah* of Ismā‘īl bin Ja‘far, since his father sees a light in his face and considers him to be “from himself.” Al-Kāfī’s commentator, al-Māzandarānī, recognizes these descriptions as clear indicators for the *imāmah* of Mūsā.⁴ So al-Kulaynī made the report ambiguous by distorting the report to say, “He is from me,” and by removing Ismā‘īl’s name. He then included the narration in a chapter called the Proof and Appointment of Abī al-Hasan Mūsā (a.s.). The report is clearly about Ismā‘īl as well since he has

¹ Al-Kulaynī, *al-Kāfī*, 2/69.

² Ibn Bābawayh, *al-Imāma wal-Tabṣira*, p. 210.

³ Muḥammad bin Yaḥyā al-‘Attār is a major Shī‘ī narrator with 3,114 reports in *al-Kāfī*. See: Al-Iyrawānī, *al-Durūs al-Tamhīdiyya fil-Qawā‘id al-Rijālīyyah*, p. 251.

⁴ Al-Māzandarānī, *Sharḥ Uṣūl al-Kāfī*, 6/180.

the same mother as ‘Abdullāh, Fāṭima bint al-Ḥusayn bin ‘Alī bin al-Ḥusayn bin ‘Alī bin Abī Ṭālib. The mother of Mūsā was Ḥamīda, an *um walad* from the Berber.¹

It should also be noted that that al-Mufīd (d. 413 AH) quotes this report a century later with the words “Aren’t my origins and his origins one?” instead of “Isn’t my mother and his mother one?” in order for the description to fit Mūsā bin Ja‘far.²

Distortion 2

Al-Kulaynī said: Muḥammad bin Yaḥyā has narrated from Aḥmad bin Muḥammad from ‘Alī bin al-Ḥakam from ‘Abd al-Raḥmān bin Kathīr from Abū Ja‘far (a.s.) who said, “The Messenger of Allah has said, ‘The first *waṣī* on earth was Hibatullāh, the son of Adam. No prophet has ever left this world without first leaving behind a *waṣī*. The prophets were one hundred twenty thousand. Five of them were the *‘ulū al-‘azm*: Nūḥ, Ibrāhīm, Mūsā, ‘Īsā, and Muḥammad (peace be upon him and his household). ‘Alī bin Abī Ṭālib (a.s.) was the ‘Hibatullāh’ for Muḥammad (peace be upon him and his household). He inherited the knowledge of the *awṣiyā*’ and those who came before him. Muḥammad (peace be upon him and his household) inherited the knowledge of the prophets and messengers who came before him. It is written on the columns of the throne, ‘Ḥamza is the lion of Allah, the lion of His messenger, and is the master of the martyrs.’ Written on the top of the throne is: ‘Alī is the Commander of the Faithful. This is our evidence against those who deny our rights and what we’ve inherited. Before us is all certainty so what good is talk? What evidence could be clearer than this?’”³

محمد بن يحيى، عن أحمد بن محمد، عن علي بن الحكم، عن عبد الرحمن بن كثير: عن أبي جعفر عليه السلام، قال: قال رسول الله صلى الله عليه وآله: إن أول وصي كان على وجه الأرض هبة الله بن آدم، وما من نبي مضى إلا وله وصي. وكان جميع الأنبياء مائة ألف نبي وعشرين ألف نبي، منهم خمسة أولو العزم: نوح، وإبراهيم، وموسى، وعيسى، ومحمد صلى الله عليه وآله، وإن علي بن أبي طالب عليه السلام كان هبة الله لمحمد صلى الله عليه وآله، وورث علم الأوصياء وعلم من كان قبله، أما إن محمدًا ورث علم من كان قبله من الأنبياء والمرسلين، على قائمة العرش مكتوب: حمزة أسد الله وأسد رسوله وسيد الشهداء، وفي ذؤابة العرش: علي أمير المؤمنين، فهذه حجتنا على من أنكر حقنا وجحد ميراثنا، وما منعنا من الكلام وأماننا اليقين؟ فأبي حجة تكون أبلغ من هذا.

This narration was also narrated by al-Ṣaffār from Aḥmad bin Muḥammad from ‘Alī bin al-Ḥakam from ‘Abd al-Raḥmān bin Bukayr⁴ al-Hajarī from Abū Ja‘far (a.s.) who said, “The

¹ Al-Ṭabṣāṣī, *I’lām al-Warā*, p. 294-295.

² Al-Mufīd, *Muṣannafāt al-Shaykh al-Mufīd*, 11/282.

³ Al-Kulaynī, *Al-Kāfī*, 1/557-558.

⁴ There is a difference of opinion in regards to his name in the books and manuscripts. See footnotes in the previous source.

Messenger of Allah said, ‘The first *waṣī* on earth was Hibatullāh, the son of Adam. No prophet has ever left this world without first leaving behind a *waṣī*. The prophets were one hundred and twenty-four thousand. Five of them were the *’ulū al-’azm*: Nūḥ, Ibrāhīm, Mūsā, ’Īsā, and Muḥammad (peace be upon him and his household). ‘Alī bin Abī Ṭālib (a.s.) was the ‘Hibatullāh’ for Muḥammad (peace be upon him and his household). He inherited the knowledge of the *awṣiyā*’ and those who came before him. Muḥammad (peace be upon him and his household) inherited the knowledge of the prophets and messengers who came before him. It is written on the columns of the throne, ‘Ḥamza is the lion of Allah, the lion of His messenger, and is the master of the martyrs.’ Written on the edges of the throne, to the right of its Lord, and both His hands are right, is: ‘Alī is the Commander of the Faithful. This is our evidence against those who deny our rights and what we’ve inherited. Before us is all certainty so what good is talk? What evidence could be clearer than this?’¹

الصفار: حدثنا أحمد بن محمد عن علي بن الحكم عن عبد الرحمن بن بكير الهجري: عن أبي جعفر عليه السلام، قال: قال رسول الله صلى الله عليه وآله: إن أول وصي كان على وجه الأرض هبة الله بن آدم، وما من نبي مضى إلا وله وصي، وكان جميع الأنبياء مائة ألف نبي وأربع وعشرين ألف نبي، منهم خمسة أولو العزم: نوح وإبراهيم وموسى وعيسى ومحمد صلى الله عليه وآله، وإن علي بن أبي طالب عليه السلام كان هبة الله لمحمد صلى الله عليه وآله، ورث علم الأوصياء، وعلم من كان قبله، أما إن محمدًا صلى الله عليه وآله ورث علم من كان قبله من الأنبياء والمرسلين، وعلى قائمة العرش مكتوب حمزة أسد الله وأسد رسوله وسيد الشهداء، وفي زوايا العرش مكتوب عن يمين ربها وكلتا يديه يمين علي أمير المؤمنين عليه السلام، فهذه حجتنا على من أنكر حقنا وجحد ميراثنا وما منعنا من الكلام، وأماننا اليقين، فأبي حجة تكون أبلغ من هذا.

The narration was been tampered with due to it affirming “two right hands” for Allah the Almighty. The narration, in its original form, is in line with what is ascribed to early Qummī scholarship. Al-Sharīf al-Murtaḍā points out that “Just until yesterday, all the people of Qum, with the exception of Abū Ja‘far ibn Bābawayh were anthropomorphists and fatalists. Their books and works testify to this and express it.”² The term anthropomorphists is also used by deniers of attributes of Allah for anyone that affirms them.

Distortion 3

Al-Kulaynī said: A number of our companions narrated from Aḥmad bin Muḥammad from ‘Alī bin al-Nu‘mān from Muḥammad bin Marwān from al-Fuḍayl bin Yasār who said: “I heard Abū Ja‘far (a.s.) say, ‘One who would die without an Imam dies a death of the period of ignorance.

¹ Al-Ṣaffār, *Baṣā’ir al-Darajāt*, p.170-171.

² Al-Murtaḍā, *Rasā’il al-Sharīf al-Murtaḍā*, 3/310.

One who dies and knows his Imam won't be harmed by the coming of this matter earlier or later. One who dies knowing his Imam is like the one present with the Qā'im in his tent.”¹

قال الكليني: عدة من أصحابنا، عن أحمد بن محمد، عن علي بن النعمان، عن محمد بن مروان، عن فضيل بن يسار، قال: سمعت أبا جعفر عليه السلام يقول: من مات وليس له إمام، فميتته ميتة جاهلية، ومن مات وهو عارف لإمامه، لم يضره تقدم هذا الأمر أو تأخر، ومن مات وهو عارف لإمامه، كان كمن هو مع القائم في فسطاطه.

This report was also narrated by al-Barqī from his father, from ‘Alī bin al-Nu‘mān from Muḥammad bin Marwān from al-Fuḍayl bin Yasār who said: “I heard Abū Ja‘far (a.s.) say, ‘One who would die without an Imam dies a death of the period of ignorance, and one won't be excused until they know their Imam. One who dies and knows his Imam won't be harmed by the coming of this matter whether it is early or late. One who dies knowing his Imam is like the one present with the Qā'im in his tent.’”²

البرقي عن أبيه، عن علي بن النعمان، عن محمد بن مروان، عن الفضيل بن يسار، قال: سمعت أبا جعفر عليه السلام يقول: من مات وليس له إمام مات ميتة جاهلية، ولا يعذر الناس حتى يعرفوا إمامهم، ومن مات وهو عارف لإمامه لا يضره تقدم هذا الأمر أو تأخره، ومن مات عارفاً لإمامه كان كمن هو مع القائم في فسطاطه.

The underlined sentence may have been removed due to it contradicting the concept of excuse by ignorance. The narration directly contradicts others in *al-Kāfī* that point out that not being familiar with these differences is a reason for one to be excused.³

Distortion 4

Al-Kulaynī said: Muḥammad bin Yaḥyā has narrated from Muḥammad bin al-Ḥusayn from Muḥammad bin Ismā‘īl bin Bazī‘ from his uncle Ḥamza bin Bazī‘ from ‘Alī bin Suwayd from Abū al-Ḥasan Mūsā bin Ja‘far (a.s.) who said about the words of Allah “Woe to me because of my failure to fulfill my duties from the side of God...” (39:56). He said, “The ‘side of Allah’ is the Commander of the Faithful (a.s.) and so are the successors at the high position, until the last of them.”⁴

¹ Al-Kulaynī, *Al-Kāfī*, 2/251.

² Al-Barqī, *al-Maḥāsīn*, 1/254.

³ Al-Kulaynī, *Al-Kāfī*, 4/183.

⁴ Al-Kulaynī, *Al-Kāfī*, 1/354-355.

قال الكليني: محمد بن يحيى، عن محمد بن الحسين، عن محمد بن إسماعيل بن بزيع، عن عمه حمزة بن بزيع، عن علي بن سويد: عن أبي الحسن موسى بن جعفر عليه السلام في قول الله عز وجل: (يا حسرتي على ما فرطت في جنب الله) قال: جنب الله أمير المؤمنين عليه السلام، وكذلك ما كان بعده من الأوصياء بالمكان الرفيع إلى أن ينتهي الأمر إلى آخرهم.

This report was narrated by al-Ṣaffār from Aḥmad bin Muḥammad from al-Ḥusayn bin Sa'īd from Muḥammad bin Ismā'īl bin Bazī' from his uncle Ḥamza bin Bazī' from 'Alī al-Sā'ī: I asked Abū al-Ḥasan al-Reḍā (a.s.), the previous Abū al-Ḥasan (a.s.),¹ about the words of Allah, "Woe to me because of my failure to fulfill my duties from the side of God and I was indeed among the scoffers." (39:56) He said, "The 'side of Allah' is the Commander of the Faithful (a.s.) and so are the successors at the high position, until the last of them, and Allah knows best as to who comes after him."²

قال الصفار: حدثنا أحمد بن محمد، عن الحسين بن سعيد، عن محمد بن إسماعيل بن حمزة بن بزيع عن علي السائي قال: سألت أبا الحسن الرضا عليه السلام أبا الحسن الماضي عن قوله عز وجل: (أن تقول نفس يا حسرتي على ما فرطت في جنب الله وإن كنت لمن الساخرين) قال: جنب الله هو أمير المؤمنين، وكذلك من كان من بعده من الأوصياء بالمكان المرفوع، إلى أن ينتهي الأمر إلى آخرهم، والله أعلم بمن هو كائن بعده.

The narration suggests that there will be an authority after the last Imam and that this knowledge isn't accessible to Mūsā bin Ja'far, hence, the end of the report was dropped. It also contradicts a report in *al-Kāfī* which states that the Imams have a book that lists the names of all future kings.³

Distortion 5

Al-Kulaynī said: Muḥammad bin Yaḥyā has narrated from Aḥmad bin Muḥammad from 'Alī bin al-Ḥakam from Rabī' bin Muḥammad al-Muslī from 'Abdillāh bin Sulaymān al-Āmirī from Abū 'Abdillāh (a.s.) who said, "The earth will always have a *ḥujjah* (i.e. prophet, imam, etc...) who would teach people about the lawful and unlawful matters, and call them to the path of Allah."⁴

قال الكليني: محمد بن يحيى، عن أحمد بن محمد، عن علي بن الحكم، عن ربيع بن محمد المسلي، عن عبد الله بن سليمان العامري: عن أبي عبد الله عليه السلام، قال: ما زالت الأرض إلا والله فيها الحجة، يعرف الحلال والحرام، ويدعو الناس إلى سبيل الله.

¹ The published edition mentions both Abū Ḥasan al-Reḍā and al-Kāzīm, which is a clear error, since this narration is by al-Kāzīm exclusively.

² Al-Ṣaffār, *Baṣā'ir al-Darajāt*, p. 93.

³ Al-Kulaynī, *Al-Kāfī*, 1/601.

⁴ Al-Kulaynī, *Al-Kāfī*, 1/434-435.

This narration was also reported by al-Barqī from ‘Alī bin al-Ḥakam from Rabī‘ bin al-Muslī from ‘Abdillāh bin Sulaymān al-‘Āmirī from Abī ‘Abdillāh (a.s.) who said, “The earth will always have a *ḥujjah* (i.e. prophet, imam, etc...) who would teach people about the lawful and unlawful matters, and call them to the path of Allah. The *ḥujjah* will not be separated from earth for more than forty days before the Day of Judgment, and once the *ḥujjah* is lifted, the door of repentance closes, and one’s acceptance of faith at that time will not benefit it if it did not have faith before the lifting of the *ḥujjah*. Those are the worst of the creation of Allah and upon them the Day of Judgment commences.”¹

رواه البرقي: عن علي بن الحكم، عن الربيع بن المسي، عن عبد الله بن سليمان العامري، عن أبي عبد الله عليه السلام، قال: ما زالت الأرض والله فيها حجة يعرف الحلال والحرام، ويدعو إلى سبيل الله، ولا تنقطع الحجة من الأرض إلا أربعين يومًا قبل يوم القيامة، فإذا رفعت الحجة أغلق باب التوبة، ولم ينفع نفسًا إيمانها، لم تكن آمنت من قبل أن ترفع الحجة، وأولئك شرار من خلق الله، وهم الذين تقوم عليهم القيامة.

The report was also narrated in *Baṣā’ir al-Darajāt*: Aḥmad bin Muḥammad narrated to us from ‘Alī bin al-Ḥakam from Rabī‘ bin al-Maslamī from ‘Abdillāh bin Sulaymān al-‘Āmirī from Abī ‘Abdillāh (a.s.) who said, “The earth will always have a *ḥujjah* (i.e. prophet, imam, etc...) who would teach people about the lawful and unlawful matters, and call them to the path of Allah. The *ḥujjah* will not be separated from earth for more than forty days before the Day of Judgment, and once the *ḥujjah* is lifted, the door of repentance closes, and one’s acceptance of faith at that time will not benefit it if it did not have faith before the lifting of the *ḥujjah*. Those are the worst of the creation of Allah and upon them the Day of Judgment commences.”²

البصائر الدرجات: حدثنا أحمد بن محمد عن علي بن الحكم عن ربيع بن محمد المسلمي عن عبد الله بن سليمان العامري عن أبي عبد الله عليه السلام قال: ما زالت الأرض إلا والله الحجة يعرف الحلال والحرام ويدعو إلى سبيل الله ولا تنقطع الحجة من الأرض إلا أربعين يومًا قبل يوم القيامة، فإذا رفعت الحجة أغلق باب التوبة ولا ينفع نفسًا إيمانها لم تكن آمنت من قبل أن ترفع الحجة أولئك شرار من خلق الله، وهم الذين عليهم تقوم القيامة.

The reason for the omission is that the earth isn’t supposed to last a day without an Imam, let alone forty, which is what we find in the same chapter in *al-Kāfī*.³

¹ Al-Barqī, *al-Maḥāsīn*, 1/368.

² Al-Ṣaffār, *Baṣā’ir al-Darajāt*, p. 634.

³ Al-Kulaynī, *Al-Kāfī*, 1/438.

Distortion 6

Al-Kulaynī said: A number of our companions narrated from Aḥmad bin Muḥammad from ‘Abdillāh al-Ḥajjāl from Aḥmad bin ‘Umar al-Ḥalabī from Abū Baṣīr – in a long narration - from Abū ‘Abdillāh (a.s.), where he said: He (Abū ‘Abdillāh) remained silent for a while and then said, “We have the *muṣḥaf* of Fāṭima (a.s.) and what do they know of the *muṣḥaf* of Fāṭima?” I asked, “What is the *muṣḥaf* of Fāṭima (a.s.)?” He said, “A *muṣḥaf* that is three times the size of your Qur’ān. There is not even a single letter therein from your Qur’ān.” I then said, “This, by Allah, is the knowledge.” He said, “This certainly is knowledge, but it is not all that.”¹

قال الكليني: عدة من أصحابنا، عن أحمد بن محمد، عن عبد الله الحجال، عن أحمد بن عمر الحلبي، عن أبي بصير، قال: دخلت على أبي عبد الله عليه السلام - في حديث طويل - قال: ثم سكت ساعة، ثم قال: وإن عندنا لمصحف فاطمة عليها السلام، وما يدرهم ما مصحف فاطمة عليها السلام؟ قال: قلت: وما مصحف فاطمة عليها السلام؟ قال: مصحف فيه مثل قرآنكم هذا ثلاث مرات، والله ما فيه من قرآنكم حرف واحد. قال: قلت: هذا والله العلم، قال: إنه لعلم، وما هو بذلك. ثم سكت ساعة، ثم قال: إن عندنا علم ما كان، وعلم ما هو كائن إلى أن تقوم الساعة. قال: قلت: جعلت فداك، هذا والله هو العلم، قال: إنه لعلم، وليس بذاك.

Al-Ṣaffār also narrated this tradition from Aḥmad bin Muḥammad from al-Ḥusayn bin Sa‘īd al-Jammāl² from Aḥmad bin ‘Umar from Abū Baṣīr that - in a lengthy narration - from Abū ‘Abdillāh (a.s.), where he said: He (Abū ‘Abdillāh) remained silent for a while and then said, “We have the *muṣḥaf* of Fāṭima (a.s.) and what do they know of the *muṣḥaf* of Fāṭima?” He said, “It is a *muṣḥaf* that is three times the size of your Qur’ān. There is not even a single letter therein from your Qur’ān, but it is something that was dictated and inspired to her by Allah.” I then said, “This, by Allah, is the knowledge.” He said, “This certainly is knowledge, but it is not all that.”³

قال الصفار حدثنا أحمد بن محمد عن الحسين بن سعيد الجمال عن أحمد بن عمر عن أبي بصير: قال: دخلت على أبي عبد الله عليه السلام، - في حديث طويل - قال: ثم سكت ساعة ثم قال: وإن عندنا لمصحف فاطمة عليها السلام وما يدرهم ما مصحف فاطمة؟ قال: مصحف فيه مثل قرآنكم هذا ثلاث مرات، والله ما فيه من قرآنكم حرف واحد، إنما هو شيء أملاها الله وأوحى إليها، قال: قلت: هذا والله هو العلم، قال: إنه لعلم وليس هو بذاك.

The narration has been tampered with because it states that Fāṭima (a.s.) received a Qur’ān through dictation and inspiration, implying that she was a prophetess.

¹ Al-Kulaynī, *Al-Kāfī*, 1/592-596.

² This is his name in the published edition which is a name that doesn’t exist in any source. The editors of *al-Kāfī* point out that some manuscripts of *al-Baṣā’ir* have him as ‘Abdullāh bin Muḥammad al-Ḥajjāl, like *al-Kāfī*.

³ Al-Ṣaffār, *Baṣā’ir al-Darajāt*, p. 209-210.

Distortion 7

Al-Kulaynī said: A number of our companions narrated from Aḥmad bin Muḥammad al-Barqī from Abū Hāshim Dāwūd bin al-Qāsim al-Jaʿfarī from Abū Jaʿfar II who said: “Once, the Commander of the Faithful Ali (a.s.) came with al-Ḥasan bin ʿAlī, while being supported by Salmān. He entered the Sacred Mosque and sat down. Then a good looking and well-dressed man came. He offered the greeting of peace to the Commander of the Faithful (a.s.), who answered his greetings. He then sat down. He then said, ‘O Commander of the Faithful, I will ask you three questions, if you would answer them I’ll acknowledge that the people who have acted against you in the matters of leadership that has been ruled upon them, and that they aren’t trustworthy in worldly or religious affairs. If you cannot answer, then you and those people are the same.’ The Commander of the Faithful (a.s.) said, ‘Ask whatever you like.’ He said, ‘Tell about where does the soul go when one sleeps, how one remembers and forgets, and how does one resemble their paternal and maternal uncles?’ The Commander of the Faithful (a.s.) turned to al-Ḥasan and said, ‘O Abū Muḥammad, answer him.’ So al-Ḥasan (a.s.) answered his questions. The man then said, ‘I testify that there is no god besides Allah and I’ve always testified to this. I testify that Muḥammad is the messenger of Allah and I’ve always testified to this. I testify that you are the *waṣī* of the Messenger of Allah and that you carry his authority after him.’ He pointed to the Commander of the Faithful (a.s.) and said, ‘And I’ve always testified to this.’ He then said, ‘And I testify that you are his *waṣī* that you carry his authority,’ and he pointed to al-Ḥasan (a.s.). Then he said, ‘And I testify that al-Ḥusayn bin ʿAlī will be the *waṣī* of his brother and carry his authority after him. And I testify in that ʿAlī bin al-Ḥusayn will carry the matters of al-Ḥusayn after him. I testify that Muhammad bin ʿAlī will carry the matters of ʿAlī bin al-Ḥusayn. I testify that Jaʿfar bin Muhammad will carry the matters of Muhammad. I testify that Mūsā will carry the matters of Jaʿfar bin Muhammad. I testify that ʿAlī bin Mūsā will carry the matters of Mūsā bin Jaʿfar. I testify that Muhammad bin ʿAlī will carry the matters of ʿAlī bin Mūsā. I testify that ʿAlī bin Muhammad will carry the matters of Muhammad bin ʿAlī. I testify that al-Ḥasan bin ʿAlī will carry the matters of ʿAlī bin Muhammad. I testify that a man from the children of al-Ḥasan who will not be mentioned by his *kunya* or his name until he appears, will fill the earth with justice like it was filled with injustice. Peace, mercy, and blessings of Allah be upon you O Commander of the Faithful.’ He then stood up and left. The Commander of the Faithful said, “O Abū Muḥammad, follow him and see where he went.” Al-Ḥasan bin ʿAlī (a.s.) left to follow him. He said, ‘As soon as he stepped out of the mosque I could not figure out where in the earth of Allah he went, so I returned to the Commander of the Faithful (a.s.) and informed him.’ He said, ‘O Abū Muḥammad, do you who that was?’ I said, ‘Allah, the Messenger of Allah, and the Commander of the Faithful know best.’ He said, ‘It was al-Khiḍr (a.s.).’”¹

¹ Al-Kulaynī, *Al-Kāfī*, 2/677-680.

قال الكليني: عدة من أصحابنا، عن أحمد بن محمد البرقي، عن أبي هاشم داود بن القاسم الجعفري: عن أبي جعفر الثاني عليه السلام، قال: أقبل أمير المؤمنين عليه السلام ومعه الحسن بن علي عليه السلام وهو متكئ على يد سلمان، فدخل المسجد الحرام، فجلس، إذ أقبل رجل حسن الهيئة واللباس، فسلم على أمير المؤمنين فرد عليه السلام، فجلس، ثم قال: يا أمير المؤمنين، أسألك عن ثلاث مسائل إن أخبرني بهن، علمت أن القوم ركبوا من أمرك ما قضي عليهم، وأن ليسوا بمؤمنين في دنياهم وآخرتهم، وإن تكن الأخرى، علمت أنك وهم شرع سواء، فقال له أمير المؤمنين عليه السلام: سلني عما بدا لك. قال: أخبرني عن الرجل إذا نام أين تذهب روحه؟ وعن الرجل كيف يذكر وينسى؟ وعن الرجل كيف يشبه ولده الأعمام والأخوال؟ فالتفت أمير المؤمنين عليه السلام إلى الحسن، فقال: يا أبا محمد، أجبه. قال فأجابه الحسن عليه السلام، فقال الرجل: أشهد أن لا إله إلا الله، ولم أزل أشهد بها، وأشهد أن محمدًا رسول الله، ولم أزل أشهد بذلك، وأشهد أنك وصي رسول الله صلى الله عليه وآله والقائم بحجته – وأشار إلى أمير المؤمنين عليه السلام – ولم أزل أشهد بها، وأشهد أنك وصيه والقائم بحجته – وأشار إلى الحسن عليه السلام – وأشهد أن الحسين بن علي وصي أخيه والقائم بحجته بعده، وأشهد على علي بن الحسين أنه القائم بأمر الحسين بعده، وأشهد على محمد بن علي أنه القائم بأمر علي بن الحسين، وأشهد على جعفر بن محمد بأنه القائم بأمر محمد، وأشهد على موسى أنه القائم بأمر جعفر بن محمد، وأشهد على علي بن موسى أنه القائم بأمر موسى بن جعفر، وأشهد على محمد بن علي أنه القائم بأمر علي بن محمد، وأشهد على علي بن محمد بأنه القائم بأمر محمد بن علي، وأشهد على الحسن بن علي بأنه القائم بأمر علي بن محمد، وأشهد على رجل من ولد الحسن لا يكنى ولا يسمى حتى يظهر أمره، فيملأها عدلاً، كما ملئت جوراً، والسلام عليك يا أمير المؤمنين ورحمة الله وبركاته. ثم قام فمضى، فقال أمير المؤمنين: يا أبا محمد، اتبعه، فانظر أين يقصد، فخرج الحسن بن علي عليه السلام، فقال: ما كان إلا أن وضع رجله خارجاً من المسجد، فما دريت أين أخذ من أرض الله، فرجعت إلى أمير المؤمنين عليه السلام فأعلمته، فقال: يا أبا محمد، أتعرفه؟ قلت: الله ورسوله وأمير المؤمنين أعلم. قال: هو الخضر عليه السلام.

Al-Kulaynī then quoted his teacher Muḥammad bin Yaḥyā who said: “I told Muḥammad bin al-Ḥasan (al-Ṣaffār), O Abū Ja‘far, I wish this report came to us from someone other than Aḥmad bin Abī ‘Abdillāh (al-Barqī).” He said: “He narrated this to me before the period of confusion by ten years.”

Muḥammad bin Yaḥyā problematized that al-Barqī was the sole narrator of this report which listed the names of all twelve Imams. The report itself can be found in another famous source, *Tafsīr al-Qummī*, without the names of the Imams at all.¹

His skepticism is natural since Abū Hāshim al-Ja‘farī (d. 261 AH) allegedly heard this narration from al-Jawād (d. 220 AH), then stayed alive for another forty more years. How likely is it for him to narrate a vital report listing the twelve Imams to only one person?

¹ Al-Qummī, *Tafsīr al-Qummī*, p. 590-591.

However, it is unlikely that this discussion between Muḥammad bin Yaḥyā and al-Ṣaffār ever happened in the first place. If al-Ṣaffār (d. 290 AH) heard this report ten years before the “period of confusion,” then that would’ve been in the year 250, forty years before passing away. Why wouldn’t he include such an important report in *Baṣā’ir al-Darajāt*, a book that is all about the Imams?

Fortunately, we also have access to al-Barqī’s book that provides the same narration as al-Kulaynī, but with a few major changes.

Al-Barqī narrates from his father from Abū Hāshim al-Ja‘farī, a disconnected narration¹ from Abū ‘Abdillāh (a.s.): “The Commander of the Faithful (a.s.) entered the mosque along with al-Ḥasan. A man entered and greeted him, and so the greeting was met and returned. He said: ‘O Commander of the Faithful, I come with questions.’ He said: ‘Ask away.’ He said: ‘Tell me where a man’s soul goes when he sleeps, how a child looks like his father, and how one remembers and forgets?’ He said: ‘The Commander of the Faithful looked at al-Ḥasan (a.s.) and said, ‘Answer him.’ Al-Ḥasan said: ‘When a man goes to sleep, his soul is connected to air, which is connected to the wind, if Allah wishes to take away his soul, the wind would pull the air, and the air would pull the soul, and if Allah wanted to return it to its place, the soul would pull the air, and the air would pull the wind, until it returns to its place. As for the child looking like his father, if a man had intercourse with his wife with a calm mind and balanced body, when the sperm enters the womb, the newborn looks like the father. If he has intercourse with an occupied mind and imbalanced body, when the sperm enters the womb, if it reaches a paternal uncle’s vein, the newborn looks like his paternal uncle, and if it reaches a maternal uncle’s vein, the newborn looks like his maternal uncle. As for remembering and forgetting, the heart is upon truth and truth covers it. If Allah wants to remind the heart, the cover falls, and one remembers.’ The man said: ‘I testify that there is no god but Allah, and He has no partners, and I testify that Muḥammad is His servant and messenger. I testify that your father, the Commander of the Faithful is surely the *waṣī* of Muḥammad, and I’ve always testified to this. I also testify that you are his *waṣī* and that al-Ḥusayn is your *waṣī*, until the last of them.’” He (the narrator) said to Abū ‘Abdillāh (a.s.), “Who was the man?” He replied, “It was al-Khiḍr (a.s.).”²

دخل أمير المؤمنين صلوات الله عليه المسجد، ومعه الحسن عليه السلام، فدخل رجل فسلم عليه، فرد عليه شيئاً بسلامه، فقال: يا أمير المؤمنين جئت أسألك، فقال: سل، قل: أخبرني عن الرجل إذا نام أين تكون روحه، وعن المولود الذي يشبه أباه كيف يكون؟ وعن الذكر والنسيان كيف يكونان؟ قال: فنظر أمير المؤمنين عليه السلام إلى الحسن عليه السلام، فقال: أجبه، فقال الحسن: إن الرجل إذا نام فإن روحه متعلقة بالريح، والريح متعلقة بالهواء، فإذا أراد الله أن يقبض روحه جذب الهواء الريح، وجذبت الريح الروح، وإذا أراد الله أن

¹ The original report in al-Barqī’s book has Abū Hāshim quoting an Imam he never met, making it weak. Later works, like al-Kāfī, have him narrating from al-Jawād Abū Ja‘far II, in order to strengthen the chain of transmission. Late reports also discard his father from the chain, perhaps due to criticisms made against him as a narrator. See: Al-Najāshī, *Rijāl al-Najāshī*, p. 335.

² Al-Barqī, *al-Maḥāsin*, 2/59-60.

يردها في مكانها، جذبت الروح الريح، وجذبت الريح الهواء، فعادت إلى مكانها. وأما المولود الذي يشبه أباه، فإن الرجل إذا واقع أهله بقلب ساكن وبدن غير مضطرب، وقعت النطفة في الرحم، فيشبه الولد أباه، وإذا واقعها بقلب شاغل وبدن مضطرب، وقعت النطفة في الرحم، فإن وقعت على عرق من عروق أعمامه، يشبه الولد أعمامه، وإن وقعت على عروق من عروق أخواله، يشبه الولد أخواله. وأما الذكر والنسيان، فإن القلب في حق، والحق مطبق عليه، فإذا أراد الله أن يذكر القلب، سقط الطبق فذكر، فقال الرجل: أشهد أن لا إله إلا الله وحده لا شريك له، وأشهد أن محمدًا عبده ورسوله، وأشهد أن أباك أمير المؤمنين وصي محمد حقًا حقًا، ولم أزل أقوله، وأشهد أنك وصيه، وأشهد أن الحسين وصيك، حتى أتى على آخرهم. فقال: قلت لأبي عبد الله عليه السلام: فمن كان الرجل؟ قال: الخضر عليه السلام.

The report, in *al-Maḥāsin*, which was written in the 3rd century only lists three of the Imams. The book does not contain a single reference to twelve Imams either.

Late versions of the report, starting with al-Kulaynī, include all twelve. Some may try to defend the version in *al-Kāfī* by pointing out the version of the report by Ibn Bābawayh. However, he too is known to have tampered with reports in order to include the names of the Imams.¹ The same can be said about al-Nu‘mānī, a student of al-Kulaynī, who distorts a narration saying that the occultation will only be for “six days, six months, or six years” to “a long period of time.”²

¹ Al-Baḥrainī, *Taḥrīfāt al-Ṣadūq*, p. 38.

² Al-Kulaynī, *al-Kāfī*, 2/150-152; Al-Nu‘mānī, *al-Ġayba*, p. 68-69.

Conclusions

Like his spiritual successor al-Ṣadūq, al-Kulaynī is guilty of tampering with reports that conflict with his ideology. The number of distortions by al-Ṣadūq in my previous study was much greater, reaching forty in total. However, that is due to the scope of the study, which encompassed all of his books, around 20,000 reports. This study was limited to the first half of *Uṣūl al-Kāfī*, the first two volumes of the *Dār al-Ḥadīth* edition, only 1,448 reports out of 15,413.

Since the section studied was the *Uṣūl*, it is no surprise that the distortions and evolution revolved around ideology. Two of the distortions were directly related to the identity of the Imams themselves (Distortion 1 and 7).

In the previous study, over half the distortions of al-Ṣadūq could be found in *al-Kāfī* in an earlier form. In this study, finding reports earlier than *al-Kāfī*, in order to observe evolution, was quite difficult, due to the lack of earlier sources. In fact, al-Kulaynī, in many cases is the sole compiler, through an *isnād*, for these traditions. For example, none of the reports in his chapters on the appointment of al-Ḥusayn bin ‘Alī, Ja‘far bin Muḥammad, or ‘Alī bin Muḥammad, are corroborated.¹

More extensive results can be reached with the discovery of more classical Shī‘ī manuscripts from the third century.

¹ Al-Kulaynī, *al-Kāfī*, 2/43-52, 58-62, 107-112.

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